

# Hongxian Huang

Leonard N. Stern School of Business, New York University

✉ hh1643@stern.nyu.edu 🌐 hh1643.github.io ☎ 773-709-4693

## Education

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| <b>New York University</b> , New York, USA<br>Ph.D. Candidate, Stern School of Business<br><i>Committee: Anindya Ghose (Chair), Jason Chan, Runshan Fu, Masakazu Ishihara, Fred Feinberg</i> | Sept 2022 – May 2027  |
| <b>The University of Chicago</b> , Chicago, USA<br>M.A., Computational Social Science (Economics Track)                                                                                      | Sept 2020 – June 2022 |
| <b>University of California, Berkeley</b> , Berkeley, USA<br>Exchange Student                                                                                                                | Aug 2018 – May 2019   |
| <b>Shanghai Jiao Tong University</b> , Shanghai, China<br>B.Econ. (Finance); Minor in Mathematics                                                                                            | Sept 2016 – July 2020 |

## Research Interests

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**Topics:** Generative AI/LLMs, Digital Platforms, Consumer Search and Attention, Creator Incentives

**Methodologies:** Structural Modeling, Causal Inference, Machine Learning, Analytical Modeling

## Publication

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- “Generative AI, Platform Stances, and Content Creator Behavior”, *with Runshan Fu and Anindya Ghose*
  - Forthcoming at *Information Systems Research*.

## Working Papers

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- “Designing Generative AI Search: Search Activity and Demand for Creator Content”, *with Jinglong Zhang, Jason Chan, and Anindya Ghose*
  - Winner of the *2026 Mays Business School AI Dissertation Proposal Competition*.
- “Horizontal Differentiation on Two-Sided Platforms: Cross-Network Reallocation, LLM Shocks, and Evidence from Content-Creation Platforms”, *with Masakazu Ishihara and Anindya Ghose*
  - Finalist for the Best Paper Award at the *2025 Workshop on Information Systems and Economics*.
  - Winner of the *2026 Mays Business School AI Dissertation Proposal Competition*.
  - To be submitted to *Management Science*.
- “Generative AI Search on Content Creation Platform”, *with Jinglong Zhang, Jason Chan, and Anindya Ghose*
  - To be submitted to *Information Systems Research*.

- “Gambling on Gains: Reversed Loss Aversion in Opaque Product Markets”, *with Runshan Fu and Anindya Ghose*  
– To be submitted to *Marketing Science*.
- “Price-Gouging Regulation in Response to Crisis: Causal Effects and Policy Implications”, *with Sash Vaid and Fred Feinberg*  
– To be submitted to *Management Science*.
- “Unintended Racial Consequences of “Host Residency Enforcement” on Airbnb”, *with Ian Jaeyeon Kim, Masakazu Ishihara, and Anindya Ghose*  
– To be submitted to *Management Information Systems Quarterly*.

## Awards and Grants

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| INFORMS Information Systems Society Doctoral Consortium Fellow                          | 2026      |
| Winner of the 2026 Mays Business School AI Dissertation Proposal Competition (\$10,000) | 2026      |
| AMA-Sheth Foundation Doctoral Consortium Fellow                                         | 2026      |
| J. Taggart Fellowship (\$4,000), NYU                                                    | 2026      |
| Finalist for Best Paper Award at Workshop on Information Systems and Economics          | 2025      |
| ISMS Doctoral Consortium Fellow, INFORMS Society for Marketing Science                  | 2025      |
| Selected Participant, Summer School in Dynamic Structural Econometrics                  | 2024      |
| Center for Global Economy and Business (CGEB) Research Grant (\$4,000), NYU Stern       | 2024      |
| Henry Assael Grant (\$5,000), NYU Stern                                                 | 2024      |
| Selected Participant, Northwestern Workshop on Research Design for Causal Inference     | 2023      |
| Full Scholarship, NYU Stern                                                             | 2022–2027 |
| Social Science Division Scholarship (\$20,000), UChicago                                | 2021      |
| Phoenix Research Scholarship (\$40,000), UChicago                                       | 2020      |
| Top 1% Undergraduate Thesis, SJTU                                                       | 2020      |
| Best Undergraduate Thesis, Antai School of Economics and Management, SJTU               | 2020      |
| Meritorious Winner in 2018 Mathematical Contest in Modeling (Top 8%)                    | 2018      |
| Tang Li Xin Special Scholarship, SJTU (\$1,000)                                         | 2018      |
| Dong Family Oriental Scholarship, SJTU (\$1,000)                                        | 2017      |

## Conference Presentations

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### Designing Generative AI Search: Search Activity and Demand for Creator Content

- Conference on Information Systems and Technology, 2026
- AI in Business Conference (OSU Fisher), 2026
- AI and Innovation Workshop, 2026
- China India Insights Conference, 2026
- Annual Business & Generative AI Conference at Wharton, 2026

### Horizontal Differentiation on Two-Sided Platforms: Cross-Network Reallocation, LLM Shocks, and Evidence from Content-Creation Platforms

- Conference on Information Systems and Technology, 2026

- 36<sup>th</sup> Annual POMS Conference, 2026
- The Business Implications of Generative AI at MIT, 2026
- Workshop on Information Systems and Economics, 2025

### **Generative AI, Platform Stances, and Content Creator Behavior**

- The Business Implications of Generative AI at MIT, 2026
- Conference on Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning, and Business Analytics, 2025
- Biz AI Conference at UT Dallas, 2024
- Statistical Challenges in Electronic Commerce Research, 2024
- Annual Business & Generative AI Conference at Wharton, 2023
- Workshop on Information Systems and Economics, 2023

### **Unintended Racial Consequences of “Host Residency Enforcement” on Airbnb**

- Conference on Information Systems and Technology, 2024
- Workshop on Information Systems and Economics, 2024

### **Gambling on Gains: Reversed Loss Aversion in Opaque Product Markets**

- ISMS Marketing Science Conference, 2023
- Conference on Information Systems and Technology, 2023

## **Teaching Experience**

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### **New York University, Stern School of Business**

#### **Instructor**

- MKTG-UB.0002: Introduction to Marketing, Summer 2025 (*Overall Rating: 4.6/5.0*)

### **New York University, Stern School of Business**

#### **Teaching Assistant**

- MKTG-UB 0001: Introduction to Marketing, for Prof. Joshua Lewis, Fall 2025, Fall 2026
- ECON-UB 1: Microeconomics with Algebra, for Prof. Jacob French, Spring 2025
- ECON-UB 2: Microeconomics with Calculus, for Prof. Laetitia Placido, Spring 2025
- MKTG-UB.0001: Introduction to Marketing, for Prof. Andrea Bonezzi, Winter 2025
- COR1-GB 2310: Marketing, for Prof. Ngoc Pham, Fall 2024
- COR1-GB 2110: Marketing, for Prof. Russ Winer, Fall 2024
- MKTG-GB.2365: Brand Strategy, for Prof. JP Kuehlwein, Summer 2024
- COR1-GB 2110: Consumer Behavior, for Prof. Sunder Narayanan, Summer 2024
- MKTG-UB.0002: Introduction to Marketing, for Prof. Jiarui Liu, Spring 2024
- MKTG-UB.0001: Introduction to Marketing, for Prof. Joel Steckel, Winter 2024
- MKTG-UB.46.003: Globalization of Entertainment, for Prof. Durairaj Maheswaran, Fall 2023

## **Other Research Experience**

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| Research Assistant to Prof. Fred Feinberg, University of Michigan      | 2021–2022 |
| Research Assistant to Prof. Pradeep Chintagunta, University of Chicago | 2021–2022 |
| Research Assistant to Prof. Xu Zhang, London Business School           | 2020–2021 |

## Graduate Courses

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**New York University:** Consumer Behavior I & II; Marketing Science I & II; Numerical Analysis I; Deep Learning; Computer Vision; Applied Statistics; Bayesian ML; Empirical IO I & II; Behavioral Research Methods; Econometrics I & II; Advanced Empirical Methods; Game Theory I

**Stanford University (Artificial Intelligence Program):** Reinforcement Learning; Natural Language Processing; Machine Learning with Graphs; Deep Reinforcement Learning

**University of Chicago:** Advanced Microeconomics I & II; Machine Learning; Foundations in Advanced Quantitative Marketing; Bayesian Methods; Dynamic Programming & Markov Decision Processes; Probability & Statistics

**University of California, Berkeley:** Stochastic Process; Advanced Econometrics II

## Referee Activities

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Information Systems Research

Ad Hoc Reviewer

Conference on Information Systems and Technology

Reviewer, 2024–2026

## Computer Skills and Languages

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**Programming:** Matlab; R; Python; Julia; Stan; Stata; LaTeX

**Languages:** Mandarin (native), Shanghainese (native), English (fluent)

## References

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### Anindya Ghose (Chair)

Heinz Riehl Professor of Business

Professor of Technology, Operations, & Statistics  
and Professor of Marketing

NYU Stern School of Business

☎ +1 (212) 998-0807

✉ ag122@stern.nyu.edu

### Jason Chan

Professor, Mary and Jim Lawrence Fellow

Information & Decision Sciences

Carlson School of Management, University of  
Minnesota

☎ +1 (612) 626-9974

✉ jchanf@umn.edu

### Masakazu Ishihara

Professor of Marketing

Coordinator, PhD Program in Marketing

NYU Stern School of Business

☎ +1 (212) 998-0553

✉ mi25@stern.nyu.edu

### Runshan Fu

Assistant Professor of Marketing

Marketing Department

NYU Stern School of Business

☎ +1 (212) 998-0500

✉ rf2583@stern.nyu.edu

### Fred Feinberg

Joseph Handleman Professor of Marketing

Professor of Statistics (by courtesy)

Stephen M. Ross School of Business, University of  
Michigan

☎ +1 (734) 764-4711

✉ feinfe@umich.edu

## Abstracts

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- **“Generative AI, Platform Stances, and Content Creator Behavior”**

Forthcoming at *Information Systems Research*.

Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) technologies have emerged as a transformative force in the content creator economy. This paper examines how the AI stances signaled by specific platform policy decisions shape creator behavior on visual arts platforms. We leverage two independent natural experiments on leading Chinese platforms: Lofter’s launch of an AI image generator, which signaled a pro-AI stance, and Graffiti Kingdom’s prohibition of AI-generated artwork, which signaled an anti-AI stance. Our analysis shows that creators decreased their activity on Lofter following the AI generator launch, while activity increased on Graffiti Kingdom after the AI prohibition. Multiple lines of evidence show these effects stem from policy-communicated stance signaling: creators respond to what the focal AI policy communicates about AI’s role, the platform’s commitment to human creators, and the future competitive environment for human-created work, rather than merely to specific tool features or enforcement actions. Heterogeneity analysis reveals that higher-popularity, multi-homing, and AI-averse creators show larger activity reductions on Lofter. Through analysis of creator posts, we identify three primary concerns driving resistance: replacement risk, perceived low quality, and copyright infringement. To our knowledge, this is the first paper to causally identify how the AI stance signaled by a platform policy decision affects creator behavior. Our findings have implications for how platforms communicate AI-related policy decisions, and for policymakers on fostering a constructive relationship between AI and human creators.

- **“Designing Generative AI Search: Search Activity and Demand for Creator Content”**

Generative AI Search allows content creation platforms to answer users’ questions directly, potentially substituting for the user-generated content (UGC) they help users discover. How can platforms improve search while sustaining demand for creator content? We combine a randomized field experiment involving 100,000 users on a leading Chinese question-and-answer platform with a dynamic structural model of search. Continued access to an established AI search feature increases search frequency and the range of topics explored. Users inspect fewer UGC search results and open fewer UGC pages per session, yet both totals rise as users search more often. The model explains this scale–intensity trade-off: information acquired from AI reduces the benefit of reading additional UGC within a session, while higher expected search value encourages subsequent queries and daily search activity. Counterfactual simulations show that this trade-off can be mitigated through design. Coordinating AI placement and informativeness, or reallocating AI availability across query intents within the existing budget, can increase both search activity and UGC consumption per query. These improvements need not coincide with greater AI engagement. Optimizing for AI openings favors search expansion at the expense of UGC consumption per query, whereas helping users assess an AI answer’s information content before opening it increases search and total UGC consumption with fewer AI openings. These findings highlight the importance of designing AI search around both the intensity of creator-content consumption and the scale of demand generated by more valuable search.

- **“Horizontal Differentiation on Two-Sided Platforms: Cross-Network Reallocation, LLM Shocks, and Evidence from Content-Creation Platforms”**

To be submitted to *Management Science*.

Many two-sided platforms do not operate a single undifferentiated marketplace. Instead, they organize the same intermediation function through communities that differ in topics, norms, identities, or other non-quality attributes. We study such horizontal differentiation as a platform design choice when users allocate scarce participation resources across communities and the outside option. At first glance, this setting resembles a product-line problem: added or strengthened communities may attract new participation, but they may also cannibalize incumbent communities. We show that this logic is incomplete on a two-sided platform because reallocation across communities can propagate through cross-network feedback. We define the *cross-network reallocation effect* as the additional equilibrium response generated when an initial movement of users or effort changes participation on the opposite side of affected communities and then feeds back into the side where the movement began. The implication is that horizontal differentiation creates a portfolio-level propagation problem rather than a one-sided trade-off between expansion and cannibalization. This mechanism generates three sign-changing boundaries absent from the conventional one-sided benchmark: whether adding differentiated communities expands aggregate activity or creates net cannibalization, whether unaffected communities merely attenuate a localized shock or reverse its aggregate effect, and whether a locally beneficial policy improves platform-wide outcomes or instead reduces them.

We quantify these mechanisms using Stack Exchange around ChatGPT’s release, focusing on two of its communities: Stack Overflow and Super User. ChatGPT’s release provides a localized disruption to Stack Overflow’s asker demand and audience-feedback environment, while Super User serves as a related, comparatively stable internal alternative through which within-platform reallocation can occur. In this setting, we estimate a dynamic structural model in which askers choose question volume and difficulty composition, while answerers allocate limited weekly capacity across communities and learn about changes in Stack Overflow’s audience-feedback environment from realized feedback. Counterfactual simulations translate the mechanism into three portfolio-level implications. In stable environments, horizontal differentiation creates more value when added communities are attractive destinations for marginal answerer capacity and when their question pools generate strong answerer-side feedback; when these forces are weak, the differentiated platform can underperform the single-community benchmark. After localized shocks, the same forces make unaffected communities more valuable by helping them retain displaced answerer participation and amplify it enough to move the platform from shock attenuation to aggregate reversal. Community-targeted policies create a related portfolio trade-off: even when a policy improves the treated community, its platform-wide effect can be small or negative when the untreated community already supports expansion or post-shock resilience. In such cases, the policy carries a high opportunity cost because it pulls activity away from a community whose feedback loop is already generating substantial platform-wide value. The results imply that managers should evaluate communities by the reallocation paths they create, including where activity comes from, where it goes, and how gains and losses propagate across sides, rather than by isolated community-level performance.

- **“Generative AI Search on Content Creation Platform: Evidence from a Large-Scale Field Experiment”**

To be submitted to *Information Systems Research*.

Generative AI Search places an AI-generated answer above conventional search results. This design may improve search effectiveness while changing the attention users devote to the underlying sources. These effects are particularly important for content creation platforms, where user-generated content (UGC) attracts users and user attention sustains creator participation. We examine search activity and UGC consumption in a randomized field experiment involving 100,000 users on a leading Chinese

content creation platform. Treatment-group users retained access to an established Generative AI Search feature, while the platform removed access for control-group users. Access increased how often and how broadly users searched. Most additional same-day queries were classified as follow-up questions or distinct search tasks rather than revisions of earlier queries. The results reveal a scale–intensity trade-off in UGC consumption: consumption was lower per search session but higher in total over the experiment. Access also increased the number of search sessions in which users explored additional creator content after opening an initial UGC page. These findings show why engagement within individual searches can give an incomplete picture of how Generative AI Search affects overall demand for creator content.

- **“Gambling on Gains: Reversed Loss Aversion in Opaque Product Markets”**

To be submitted to *Marketing Science*.

Opaque products, which conceal key attributes until after purchase, have been widely adopted across various industries. Yet, empirical evidence on how such opacity influences consumer demand remains scarce. This study introduces a reference price framework to estimate demand for opaque products, focusing on blind boxes in the online retailing context. Using a unique dataset from a leading e-commerce platform, we estimate heterogeneous consumer preferences through an aggregate random coefficient logit model that incorporates gains and losses relative to reference prices.

We uncover a novel behavioral pattern of *reversed loss aversion*: consumers are more sensitive to gains than to losses when purchasing opaque products. Our findings provide the first empirical validation of this pattern in consumer decision-making using field data and demonstrate that this behavioral tendency makes the demand for opaque products fundamentally different from that of traditional products. The policy simulations show that ignoring reversed loss aversion would lead to misestimated own-price elasticity, resulting in suboptimal pricing strategies and substantial profit losses.

- **“Price-Gouging Regulation in Response to Crisis: Causal Effects and Policy Implications”**

To be submitted to *Management Science*.

Price gouging regulation (PGR) helps ensure that essential goods, e.g., medical supplies or grocery staples, remain affordable and accessible. During the COVID-19 pandemic, PGR was implemented due to widespread reports of price-gouging on such critical items. Extant research offers few insights for policymakers and marketers into how PGR influences consumer spending and sales during crises. Using Generalized Synthetic Control, we examine the overall and relative effectiveness of different types of PGR legislation, as well as the moderating effects of consumer mobility and the enactment of strict price caps. We find that PGR is generally highly effective, especially when it is not overly comprehensive and for products that are “essential” (e.g., paper towels) but not obviously related to preventing contagion (e.g., hand sanitizer). A nonparametric mediation analysis suggests that pricing alone does not fully explain PGR’s overall effectiveness, accounting for roughly 27–55%, depending on product class; moreover, it is strongly moderated by both specific price caps and consumer mobility. We further add a mechanism-focused analysis using Numerator product-category data. To determine which categories are legally essential and theoretically informative, we use eight LLMs to code 1,904 product categories against pandemic price-gouging legal materials, aggregate the ratings with a principal-factor essentiality score, and then isolate three pre-specified classes of mechanism-eligible household essentials. In these categories, hierarchical bootstrap models show modestly lower prices, sharply higher online sales, lower offline sales, and a large shift from offline to online purchasing relative to inessential categories. Our results have direct implications for

policymakers deciding whether to enact PGR as well as setting specific design features depending on locality.

- **“Unintended Racial Consequences of “Host Residency Enforcement” on Airbnb”**

To be submitted to *Management Information Systems Quarterly*.

“Host Residency Enforcement” policies have been widely adopted by cities in the US, mandating hosts of short-term rentals to reside in those properties to varying extents. For example, New York City’s “Physical Presence” policy requires hosts to remain present with guests during short-term rentals, while Los Angeles’s “Primary Residence” policy mandates hosts’ residence for at least six months annually. Similar regulations have been widely adopted across other cities. Although these policies aim to address housing issues, they may unintentionally amplify racial disparities due to existing racial discrimination on Airbnb. This paper examines whether and how “Host Residency Enforcement” policies exacerbate these racial disparities on the platform.

Our findings indicate that NYC’s “Physical Presence” policy increased the daily revenue gap between minority hosts (i.e., Hispanic and Black hosts) and White hosts by approximately \$12. Similarly, LA’s “Primary Residence” policy widened the revenue disparity specifically between Black and White hosts by about \$8, while having no significant effect on the gap between Hispanic and White hosts. Additionally, on the supply side, both policies increased the gap in the likelihood of listings remaining active between minority and White hosts; however, in LA, this effect was statistically significant only among Hispanic hosts. Moderating analysis further indicates that neighborhoods with higher income, higher proportions of White residents, and more native-born residents (i.e., neighborhoods with higher socioeconomic status) mitigate these exacerbated racial disparities. Additionally, listings signaling higher quality through their overall Airbnb ratings experienced reduced disparities. This finding suggests that statistical discrimination, primarily driven by information asymmetry, serves as a key underlying mechanism. Lastly, minority female hosts were disproportionately negatively affected compared to minority male hosts, highlighting intersectional discrimination. Although our analysis specifically focuses on NYC and LA, our findings can be generalized to other cities that have implemented the same or similar policies, as NYC and LA represent opposite ends of the regulatory stringency spectrum.

Our study is the first to demonstrate that the widely adopted “Host Residency Enforcement” policies can unintentionally amplify racial disparities on Airbnb, illustrating an important but understudied interaction between public policy and existing discrimination on online platforms. Drawing from our findings, we offer several practical recommendations for policymakers and online platforms.